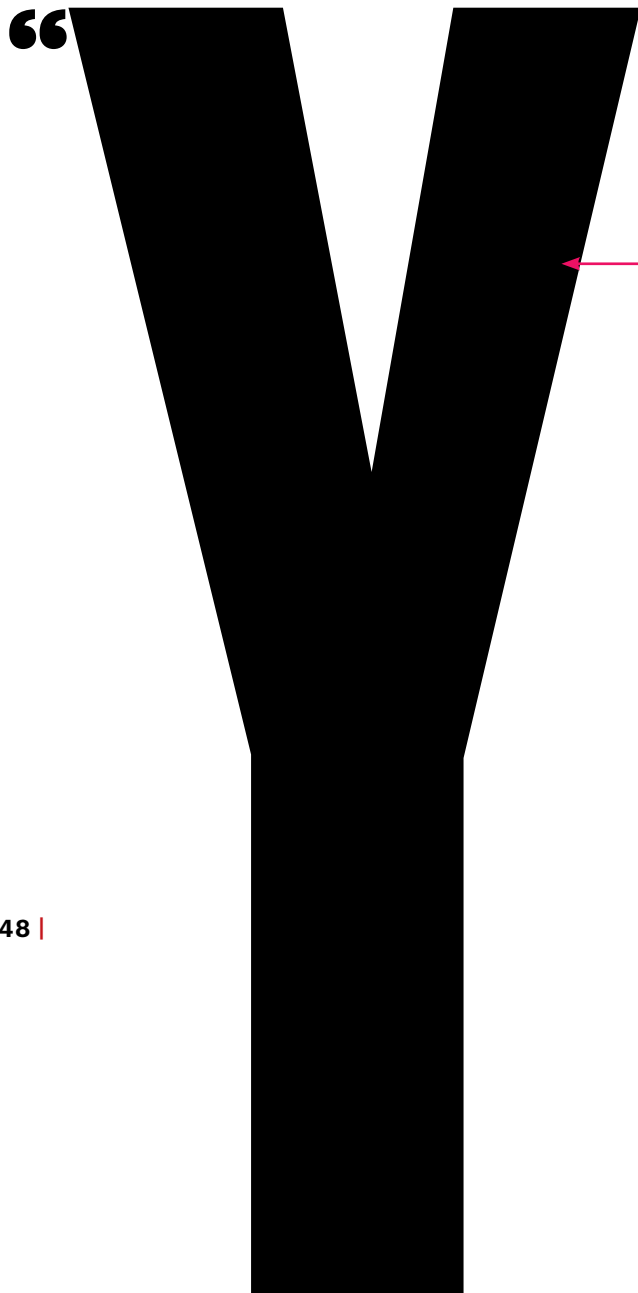




YOU ARE A woman with a man inside watching a woman. You are your own voyeur.” Margaret Atwood immortalised these lines in her novel *The Robber Bride*. More than 30 years later, this line continues to haunt many working women. Despite advances in gender equity, there is a psychological tax that often women pay at their workplace. Half a century after the term was coined by feminist film theorist Laura Mulvey, ‘male gaze’ remains an invisible architect shaping how women move, speak, present ideas, and ultimately progress in their careers.

From a lingering stare during meetings, meddling in work, suggestive messages framed as ‘jokes’, the patronising comments under the guise of “mentorship”, or the quick glance to another man for validation after a woman speaks, the male gaze pervades the agency of women at work.

“The definition under the PoSH Act is very wide and inclusive. Context matters—tone, history, intent, background. Even seemingly normal remarks may constitute harassment depending on circumstances,” says advocate Nayana Pardeshi. An Internal Committee (IC) under the Sexual Harassment of Women at Workplace (Prevention, Prohibition and Redressal) Act, 2013, commonly known as the PoSH Act, is a mandatory body in workplaces with 10 or more employees to receive and address sexual harassment complaints.

Jyotica Bhasin, Senior PoSH consultant, Advocate and External NGO Member of multiple ICs, mentions how she has seen multiple cases of “elevator eyes”, where female employees feel they have been violated by suggestive glances. On the flip side, a subtle lingering gaze, a “friendly” comment about one’s attire, seemingly harmless jokes that blur the boundaries of casual sexism may not ring alarm bells initially.

Women may not often immediately classify these micro behaviours as a threat, until they escalate. “I see more such complaints about subtle behaviour from the states in the South. In the North, behaviour is more often reported when coupled with something else, maybe a sentence, a text, or a hostile environment,” says Bhasin.

These seemingly small behaviours can actually create the biggest barriers. “A dismissive tone, interruptions, or casual stereotyping slowly chip away at confidence. Over time, they influence how women express ideas, take risks, or put themselves forward for leadership roles. When women feel constantly scrutinised, they self-edit, and organisations lose tremendous potential. Addressing this requires awareness, training, and a cultural shift where respect becomes non-negotiable,” says Sulajja Firodia

Women at Work

MOST POWERFUL WOMEN - 2025

The Male Gaze at Work

Can India Inc. truly progress if the male gaze continues to shape women’s everyday reality at work? **BY PRASHANTI MOKTAN**